Word Hoard

Accepted words and phrases for advanced learners of English

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Words

anaphora

uh-NAF-uh-ruh /əˈnæf.ə.rə/

A rhetorical device repeating a word or phrase at the start of successive clauses.

MEANINGS

1. **noun** A rhetorical device repeating a word or phrase at the start of successive clauses or sentences.
2. **noun** The use of a linguistic element that refers back to something previously mentioned.

EXAMPLES

Anaphora – repeating a word or phrase at the beginning of successive sentences or paragraphs – gives a speech force and momentum.

— The Guardian, 04 Feb 2019

Anaphora is the repetition of the same word at the beginning of successive sentences, clauses, lines or verses – it’s from the Greek, meaning “carrying back”.

— The Guardian, 21 Apr 2015

You notice he leans heavily on the repetition games of anaphora (repeating a word or phrase at the beginning of successive sentences), epistrophe (repeating one at the end) and symploce (doing both things at once, sandwich-style).

— The Guardian, 16 Jan 2017

The poet’s anaphora of ‘we’ in the speech gave it a stirring, collective rhythm.

— Example sentence

We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

repetition, reiterative structure, parallelism, reiterated phrase, redundancy

ANTONYMS

variation, non-repetition

inconsequential

in-kuhn-SEC-wen-shul /ˌɪnkənˈsɛkwənʃəl/

Not important; having little or no effect.

MEANINGS

1. **adjective** Not important; of little significance or influence.
2. **adjective** Having no effect or impact; negligible.

EXAMPLES

The longest State of the Union speech in history was also one of the most inconsequential.

— The Guardian, 25 Feb 2026

“As with many jobs, there was also some contractor error done by rushing the job,” he wrote, claiming that the damage caused by those mistakes was limited to “a very small area” and was “relatively inconsequential”.

— The Guardian, 11 Sep 2026

Following the conclusion of this weekend’s round of Premier League fixtures, football fans have what promises to be an exceptionally long, uninspiring and largely inconsequential international break to endure.

— The Guardian, 17 Sep 2026

The typo in the footnote was inconsequential to the overall argument.

— Example sentence

She brushed off the comment as inconsequential and moved on with her presentation.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

trivial, insignificant, unimportant, minor, negligible

ANTONYMS

significant, important, consequential

portend

POR-tend /ˈpɔːˌtɛnd/

to be a sign or warning of something about to happen

MEANINGS

1. **verb** To be a sign or warning that something, especially something unpleasant, will happen.

EXAMPLES

The scale of Meta’s reshaping is staggering, though, and may portend what’s to come across all of tech; we have not seen a tech giant cut up to a fifth of its workforce to offset just how massive its AI spending has become.

— The Guardian, 24 Mar 2026

The fact that the last three of his top-10 victories had all come against Fritz didn’t exactly portend a star turn against Alcaraz – who entered Tuesday’s match with a 3-0 record against Shelton.

— The Guardian, 09 Sep 2026

Mass layoffs at the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) portend a future with more infectious disease outbreaks, chronic conditions, and a widening gulf in health between the most affluent and vulnerable, experts told the Guardian.

— The Guardian, 09 Apr 2025

The sudden rise in oil prices portended a looming recession.

— Example sentence

The darkening sky portended an approaching storm.

— Example sentence

SYNONYMS

foreshadow, herald, presage, augur, signal

ANTONYMS

refute, contradict